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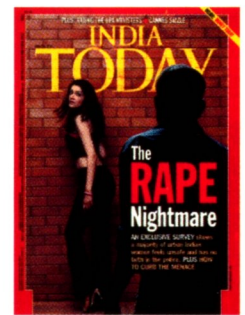
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In the last 12 months, India has been witness to a series of horrific murders which have happened in somewhat unusual circumstances. The murder of teenager Arushi Talwar in Noida became a high-profile case due to the fact that her parents were prominent city doctors. The developments in that murder overshadowed the gruesome killing of Neeraj Grover in Mumbai which added another chapter to urban India's growing list of crimes of passion.

Our country, unfortunately, is no stranger to crime or violence. Only we are accustomed to hearing about it from the rural areas where blood feuds run deep and traditions, particularly those around women, can be conservative. Urban India, on the other hand, has tended to dilute many of those old rules—or at least that's what was understood.

But a spate of crimes—14 in the last year alone—have been committed in our metros, around the complicated relationships between men and women. A model is killed by her boyfriend, a TV producer is hacked to death by his girlfriend's lover, an IT professional suspects his wife of infidelity and murders her. The victims and the perpetrators here could have been anyone we know. Educated, middle-class, working in IT, the military or media, these were the very prototypes of our urban professionals.

Ironically, it is these very factors that appear to have led to the crimes. The flip side of India's economic boom is the race to have it all, that too at an early age. High-stress, high-paying careers have led to increased ambition and sexual adventurism. Young India may enjoy its riches and explore its sexuality today but its response when things go wrong is frightening.



Our June 2007 issue

A "crime of passion" is conventionally understood as an act committed at the spur of the moment, in a fit of jealous rage. These crimes were pre-meditated but driven by the same impulses. They became, in effect, urban 'honour killings'; the honour here involving neither clan nor community but an individual who thought nothing of resorting to murder. The ham-handed nature of our police investigations and the 24/7 media machine means that the reputations of those caught in these cases are often irrevocably damaged.

Our cover story this week is about what is at work behind India's recent spate of crimes of passion. Malini Bhupta and Aditi Pai in Mumbai put the story together with countrywide inputs from our bureaus. We spoke to police officials, private detectives, psychologists, social scientists to find out why otherwise normal people have had little hesitation in committing such extreme violence. We have guest columns from psychiatrist Harish Shetty, filmmaker Kalpana Lajmi and the leader of the TV soap serial industry Ekta Kapoor.

They say that truth is stranger than fiction and nothing that Kapoor's serials have come up with can compare to what reality has thrown up at us through these crimes. New India needs to come to grips with the darkness in its heart.

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)